

Question 2 · Unit 1 · 8 Marks

Describe the evolution of Human Resource Development from traditional employee training to a strategic organisational function.

Introduction

HRD did not appear overnight. It grew as industry, labour laws and competition changed. A student who knows this history can show the examiner that HRD is more than 'old training with a new name'. The story moves from welfare and record-keeping, to skill training, to a full development system, and finally to strategic HRD linked to business goals.

Detailed points

- 1. Welfare and personnel administration stage.** In early factories, the 'people' job was welfare, attendance, discipline, wages and industrial relations. The department was often called Personnel. Development of employees was accidental. The assumption was that workers needed control, not growth. This stage created files and rules, not learning systems.
- 2. Training as a separate, short-term activity.** Wars, mass production and scientific management created a need for job-skill training — how to operate a machine, how to follow a method. Training cells ran induction and technical courses. Learning was short, job-specific and often disconnected from promotion or strategy. If production was busy, training was cancelled. This is 'traditional employee training'.
- 3. Birth of the HRD concept (Nadler, 1969).** Leonard Nadler argued that organisations needed organised learning for behavioural change — training, education and development as a field. HRD was named as something broader than a classroom. This was a turning point: learning became a designed experience with a time frame and a change purpose.
- 4. Indian HRD movement and systems view (1970s–80s).** In India, scholars such as T.V. Rao and Udai Pareek at IIMA and later HRD networks treated HRD as a system: performance appraisal, potential appraisal, feedback, counselling, training, career planning and OD working together. L&T and other firms pioneered HRD departments. The idea was climate and culture, not only courses.
- 5. From maintenance-oriented HRM to development-oriented HRD.** HRM remained responsible for staffing, pay and compliance (maintenance). HRD became the development engine. Structure also changed: HRD needed interdependence across departments, and every manager (not only the personnel officer) was made responsible for developing people.
- 6. Link with organisational strategy.** Global competition, quality movements, IT and liberalisation forced firms to ask: what capabilities do we need next year? Training calendars copied from last year were not enough. HRD began to translate strategy into competencies, leadership pipelines and change programmes. That is strategic HRD.
- 7. Today's strategic HRD function.** Modern HRD includes competency mapping, talent management, coaching, e-learning, knowledge management, diversity and learning-organisation work. The HRD professional sits with business heads, not only with trainers. Metrics (climate surveys, skill indices, succession cover) try to show contribution to performance.
- 8. What the evolution teaches an exam student.** If a company still only runs isolated workshops, it is stuck in the traditional stage. Treating HRD as strategic means: diagnosis, integration of subsystems, line-manager ownership, and alignment with business goals. Evolution is therefore a change in purpose, scope, responsibility and status of the function.

Conclusion. Write the stages in order (personnel → training cell → Nadler/HRD system → strategic HRD), name Nadler and T.V. Rao, and end by saying HRD became strategic because people capability is now a source of competitive advantage, not a welfare extra.